

Thoughts on Staples, Paul and Romans 11

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Introduction

Staples argues that Rom. 11:25-7 should be interpreted through the lens of the citation of Hos. 1:10 (in Rom. 9:25-6) and God's promise to restore a unified people from the severed pieces of "Jews" (southern kingdom) and "Israel" (a Getilized northern kingdom). This interpretation is attractive for two reasons. It appeals to the OT citations and allusions regarding Israel's restoration within the context. Further, it explains the reference to "mystery" (Rom 11:25) as OT promises whose fulfillment is revealed in Christ, a meaning that is typical of Paul (cf. Eph. 3:3, 5:32, 6:19).

Staples' interpretation provides fruitful material for reflection. Rather than assuming Scripture was written by imbeciles and patched together by mindless scribes, Staples presumes that understanding elliptical references requires deep reflection.

However, there seems little abiding depth in Staples' material. His views are deeply colored by covenantal monism (i.e., New Perspective). Although I think a "shallow" appreciation of Staple's restoration imagery is possible, I have difficulty moving beyond that. First, Staples' basic linguistic assertion of the Jew/Israel distinction has almost no explanatory value within Romans. Second, there are some obvious deeper problems that may help explain why Staples is so committed to the Jew/Israel distinction. Overall, Staples provides helpful material for reflection, but there are much better students of Paul (e.g., Gaffin, Ridderbos).

Evaluating the Jew-Israel Distinction

Core to Staples' argument is that first-century references to "Jew," including within Paul, are "necessarily limited to descendants of the southern kingdom" (p. 375). Curiously, Staples is entirely unconcerned with whether the proposal makes sense of Romans in general: there is neither argument, nor citation. A straightforward examination of the use of "Jew" within Romans raises serious doubts. Consider:

- In Rom. 2-3, "Jew" means "all of Israel" *not* "Judah." "Jew" is constantly correlated with circumcision and contrasted with either Gentiles (2:13, 24, 3:29) or Greeks (2:9-10, 3:9). Clearly, Gentiles and Greeks are interchangeable. In contrast, "Jews" represent the people of circumcision, the complement of "the Greek," which clearly mean *all* of Israel (also cf. Rom. 4). In fact, Staples himself argues (to explain the Judaizer controversy, p. 382) that circumcision-as-boundary-sign implies all of Israel.
- Interestingly, in Rom. 9:3-4 Paul's "kinsmen" and "brothers" (v. 3) are "Israelites"

(v.4) *not* Judahites. Paul associates his pre-Christian identity with (all) Israel (vs. Gentile), *not* Judah. To “Israel” was given the “covenants” “law” “worship” and “promises.”

- Critically, in Rom. 9:24 there are two problems. First, Paul distinguishes *himself* from “Jews” and uses “Jew” to mean all Israel (*not* Judah). According to Paul, God calls “us”—the elect remnant that includes *Paul himself*—from both “Jews” and “Gentiles.” Second, “Jews” means all Israel. Since the two groups (Jews and Gentiles) clearly include all people, it would be nonsense for “Jews” to leave a gap by referring only to Judah. To see this, note that throughout Rom. 9 “Gentiles” is the complement of “Israel” (v. 3-4, 30-1). Thus, both the immediate and near context implies that “Jews” (v. 24) coordinates with “Israel” (v. 4), *not* Judah.
- In Rom. 10:12, “Jew” means “all of Israel” *not* “Judah.” In v. 12 “Jew” is the complement of “Greek.” Further, “Jews” (v. 12) who reject Christ (v. 16) are part of unbelieving “Israel” (v. 19, 21). That is “Jews” and “Israel” are coordinated, not contrasted.

We now come to Rom. 11:14. There is an initial plausibility to interpreting Paul’s “fellow Jews” as “Judahites.” However, the context strongly suggests it means all Israel, *not* “Judah.” Consider 11:14 more carefully. Throughout Rom. 9-11, Paul is repeatedly concerned to show that God’s salvation comes to the *remnant* of (all) Israel, i.e., those who have the faith of Abraham. Contra Staples (p. 385), who views the olive tree (11:17) as “all Israel” representing national election, Paul’s point is that the tree’s *root* (11:16)—probably Christ, the root of Jesse (cf. 15:12)—is source of the *remnant* of (all) Israel. The implication is that when Paul calls himself a Jew, he is most concerned to contrast “Jew” with the remnant, not with a southern kingdom severed from its brothers. As already observed, in 9:24 Paul distinguished himself from “Jews” to claim membership in remnant. Paul calls himself an “Israelite” (11:1) precisely to emphasize the contrast of blood with the faith of the “remnant [like Elijah, the prophet to the *northern kingdom*], chosen by grace” (v. 5). Salvation comes to the Gentiles because of the trespass of (all) “Israel,” who pursued God’s righteousness by works (11:7, 11-12). Thus, interpreting “Jew” in 11:14 as Judahite does not fit easily within the context of Rom. 11:1-12.

For the sake of argument, let us assume that, in accordance with Staples’ claims, Paul had been trained to use “Jew” to mean southern kingdom. It is not difficult to guess why he would retire the practice. Having become a follower of Christ, and part of the new people of God (Rom. 9:24; Eph. 2:15), he counts his Mosaic national election as loss relative to Christ. He is no longer interested in his superior pedigree. During his apostolic ministry, in the heat of the church controversies (such as the Judaizers), why would he care to emphasize (esp. to *Gentiles*) distinction such as northern vs. southern kingdom? The point is not that Paul would never use “Jew” as Judah, but rather that the meaning “all Israel” almost always more naturally fits his theological arguments.

Messianic Restoration and Supersessionism

Staples caricatures supersessionism (p. 379, 383, 389). He views Messianic restoration purely in terms of the restoration of national Israel. The “mystery” (11:25) of the gospel is that the Gentiles (including Gentilized Israel) become part of “resurrected” Israel without requiring the latter to become Torah-observant like the Jews. Staples logic (and statements on Civitas Podcast) imply that Jewish [Judahite] believers in Christ retain the Torah-keeping obligation to separate themselves from Gentile believers by maintaining the Mosaic types. The conclusion is consistent with the Jewish historical expectation excepting the surprise of the Gentile inclusion. The inevitable implication appears to be a species of dispensationalism with two distinct but parallel peoples of God restored at the same time. Staples will interpret Rom. 14 in this context, namely, that both peoples legitimately exist.

This conclusion is somewhat surprising given texts like 2 Cor. 3 and Eph. 2, but it is consistent with Staples’ method of radical historical particularism. According to Staples, what are the covenant obligations of believing Jews? Should Jewish believers separate themselves from Gentile believers through circumcision and clean food? Or is nothing intrinsically unclean (14:14), which will naturally result in an abandonment of shadows over time? Should they reclaim the land? Should they rebuild the temple and reinstate sacrifices?

Although Staples is correct that the Church represents the fulfillment of God’s promises in a way that involves continuity with Israel, there is nevertheless a redemptive-historical quantum leap. The Christian Paul has radically relativized his view of Judaism or national Israel. A central theme in Rom. 9-11 is the remnant. The remnant qualifies the restoration imagery of Hos. 1:10 in Rom. 9:25-6 as v. 27 immediately cites the remnant theme from Is. 10:22-3. The restoration is not primarily national, but for the remnant. Paul clearly now views his Israelite heritage as a shadow compared his new status in Christ, a status that is shared by believing Gentiles but not by unbelieving Jews (or Judahites). The Church is not just the OT assembly of God (p. 389), but the assembly of God *in Christ*, a new people represented by Christ (Rom 5). God is literally “creating one new man out of two” (Rom 9:24, Eph. 2:15). The Church *does* represent the fulfillment of God’s promises to Israel. But it also represents the redemptive surprise that befuddled Israelites outside of Christ and (initially) even Jesus’ disciples: the fullness of salvation and restoration was always to the remnant represented by the One True Israelite, Christ. In this sense, supersessionism is a *sine qua non* to Christian belief. Contra Staples, there is a new “third race” (p. 389)—the new man of Eph. 2:15.

Covenantal Nomism

Staples holds to a form of “New Perspective” covenantal nomism that misunderstands the deeper mystery of God’s covenants. For him, there is no unconditional definitive

component to salvation. Instead, it is only conditional process: we are graciously placed into the covenant by national election but must maintain covenant faithfulness for final salvation (cf. p. 385). Election is always national and conditioned entirely on obedience. The formal basis of justification is grace *and* cooperation, i.e., a future judgment *on the basis of* works rather than according to works. Because Staples has redefined grace and salvation to be fundamentally synergistic, he sees no legalistic perversion of the gospel by the Jews that motivates Paul's polemics. Although Staples will say that second temple Judaism had some legalistic perversions, it becomes a distinction (unbelieving Jew vs. believing Judaizer) without a difference. Paul's arguments with the Judaizers are only about covenantal boundary markers, i.e., whether believing Gentiles can become part of Israel without adopting the Mosaic covenantal practices.

Unfortunately, this means that Staples must distort the fact that the Judaizers, similar to the Jewish leaders who opposed Jesus, clearly pervert Mosaic religion with legalistic elements, even if those arguments center around boundary markers. His understanding of salvation may not be Pelagian, but it is fundamentally Arminian: as with Rome, assurance is impossible. In contrast to covenantal nomism, Richard Gaffin's work is much more helpful in grappling with the mystery of definitive vs. progressive grace and justification vs. future judgment according to works (already vs. not yet).

Divine Passibility

Staples molds the potter language of Rom. 9 into a form of human cooperation based on national election and ultimate salvation conditioned on our obedience. He also has Paul teaching divine passibility and, possibly, Open Theism. The arguments are old and familiar, though of course framed cleverly.

Related Work

Jason Staples. *What Do the Gentiles Have to Do with “All Israel”? A Fresh Look at Romans 11:25-27*. Journal of Biblical Literature, JBL 130, no. 2 (2011): 371-390
<https://www.jasonstaples.com/bible/my-jbl-article-on-all-israel-will-be-saved-in-rom-1125-27-is-now-available/>

Jason Staples. *Vessels of Wrath and God’s Pathos: Potter/Clay Imagery in Rom 9:20–23*. Harvard Theological Review. 2022;115(2):197-218.
<https://dx.doi.org/10.1017/S0017816022000116>

Jason Staples. *Paul and the Resurrection of Israel: Jews, Former Gentiles, Israelites.**

Jason Staples. *Did Paul Really Think “All Israel Will Be Saved”?* (Layman presentation of the above articles on Bart Ehrman Blog.)

<https://ehrmanblog.org/did-paul-really-think-all-israel-will-be-saved-guest-post-by-jason-staples/>

<https://ehrmanblog.org/when-paul-says-israel-does-he-mean-the-jews-guest-post-by-jason-staples/>

<https://ehrmanblog.org/will-all-israel-be-saved-really-guest-post-by-jason-staples/>

<https://ehrmanblog.org/does-god-create-people-to-roast-in-hell-anniversary-guest-post-by-jason-staples/>

<https://ehrmanblog.org/nazis-and-the-meaning-of-the-word-jew-guest-post-by-jason-staples/>

Civitas Podcast. *Episode 37: Paul and the Resurrection of Israel - A Conversation with Dr. Jason Staples*.

<https://app.theopolisinstitute.com/tabs/home/podcasts/5456/episodes/37>

Gabe Harder, *Re-Considering Doug Wilson’s “Covenant with Hagar”*.
<https://theopolisinstitute.com/re-considering-doug-wilsons-covenant-with-hagar/>

Peter Leithart. <https://peterleithart.substack.com/p/paul-and-the-resurrection-of-israel>

Rich Lusk. *The Story of Israel*. <https://theopolisinstitute.com/the-story-of-israel/>

Douglas Wilson, *Children of Hagar*, <https://dougwils.com/books-and-culture/s7-engaging-the-culture/children-of-hagar.html>